

Printable Workbook

The Great War: Causes & Outbreak



Key Topic 2: The escalating conflict, 1964–1973

Cover Image: Six Day War. Army chief chaplain Rabbi Shlomo Goren, surrounded by IDF soldiers, blows the shofar in front of the Western Wall in Jerusalem. June 1967. Photograph by David Rubinger.

Unit Overview

Key Enquiry Focus	Hinge Questions (Self-Assessment)
KT2.1: The Alliance System	- Looking at a map of Europe, what is Germany's biggest geographic nightmare when facing the Triple Entente? - The alliances were designed to be purely defensive to keep countries safe. Why did they end up doing the exact opposite? - Do you think Kaiser Wilhelm II gave Austria the 'Blank Check' because he actually wanted a world war, or because he felt trapped by the alliance system?
KT2.2: The Spark in Sarajevo	- What was the single biggest piece of 'bad luck' that allowed Gavrilo Princip to assassinate the Archduke? - The Archduke was killed by a Serbian terrorist. Why on earth did Great Britain end up declaring war on Germany because of it? - After reading about the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams' and the military timetables, do you think the politicians were in charge in July 1914, or were the generals running the show?

Name:

Class:

KT2.1: The Alliance System

Enquiry: Did the alliance system provide security or guarantee a continent-wide war?

By the end of this lesson, I can:

- ☐ Identify the members of the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente.
- ☐ Explain why countries felt the need to form secret defensive treaties.
- ☐ Evaluate how the alliance system could drag all of Europe into a regional conflict.

Qundefined. Study the intertwined hands and figures in this map. What does it suggest about how a local conflict might spread?

Source A: 'The Chain of Friendship', an American cartoon published in the Brooklyn Eagle, July 1914.



What is this source showing? This cartoon shows how the complex web of alliances dragged all the European powers into war. Serbia is threatened by Austria, who is threatened by Russia, who is threatened by Germany, and so on.

Do Now Activity

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?

3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?

4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?

6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?

7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

8. PAST TOPIC: What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

9. PAST TOPIC: Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

10. PAST TOPIC: Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Vocabulary Focus

Task: Fill in the blanks in the summary below using the correct words from the word bank.

Word Bank: |

The concept of _____ is best defined as an extensive group of states or countries ruled over by a single supreme authority.. The concept of _____ is best defined as a country or area under the full or partial political control of another country.

As European empires expanded and resources grew tightly contested, nations looked for ways to keep themselves safe from sudden attack by their rivals. The primary strategy chosen by European monarchs and statesmen was the construction of binding military alliances. Gradually, over several decades, Europe was carved up into two massively armed, opposing camps.

By 1907, the European alliance system had solidified into two balanced groups. On one side stood the , consisting of the central European bloc of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. On the opposing side sat the , uniting Great Britain, France, and Russia. At the time, contemporary newspapers and diplomats argued that this delicate division of power would successfully maintain world peace. The logic was simple: going to war with any single member of an alliance meant triggering an immediate, terrible war against the entire opposing bloc. No statesman, they believed, would be reckless enough to initiate such a disaster.

Qundefined. Identify the specific member countries that made up the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente by 1907.

Qundefined. Explain the diplomatic logic of how the alliance system was theoretically supposed to keep European nations safe from a outbreak of war.

However, the alliance system did not create a sense of safety; instead, it bred intense suspicion and paranoia. The German Kaiser and his military planners viewed the Triple Entente not as a peaceful defensive bloc, but as a hostile circle of enemies designed to trap them. Historians note that from the German perspective, this amounted to a deliberate policy of meant to block Germany's legitimate right to become a global power. Crucially, the German High Command and Austria-Hungary's Chief of the General Staff, (who repeatedly advocated for a preventive war to crush Serbia), believed that a massive European war was . They feared that Russia's rapid industrialization and military growth would soon overwhelm Germany, making a preventative war necessary before Russia became too powerful. This deep-seated fear reinforced the necessity of the Schlieffen Plan—to aggressively smash France first before the massive Russian army could fully mobilise to attack from the east.

Qundefined. According to Germany's military leaders, explain why a European war was considered "inevitable and necessary" rather than avoidable.

Concurrently, the nature of war was becoming highly industrialization-driven. All the Great Powers utilized their factories to engage in a massive land-based arms race. Between 1906 and 1914, steel production in Germany skyrocketed to over 17 million tonnes, vastly outpacing Britain and France combined, to forge heavy artillery and armaments. Millions of kilometers of railway tracks were laid down across the continent for a single strategic purpose: to move hundreds of thousands of uniformed soldiers to the front lines within hours of a crisis breaking out. By 1914, Europe had been transformed into a volatile, high-density powder keg where any single local spark would automatically pull all the Great Powers into a total global slaughter.

Qundefined. Detail how the massive expansion of steel production and railway tracks across Europe altered the speed and scale of army mobilization.

Qundefined. Explain how the transformation of Europe into two "armed camps" by 1914 represented a dangerous change in international relations compared to the traditional balance of power.

Following the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, Austria-Hungary wanted to crush Serbia but feared Russian intervention. To proceed safely, Austria needed a guarantee of German support. On July 5th, 1914, Kaiser Wilhelm II issued what historians call the 'Blank Check'—an unconditional promise that Germany would stand by Austria-Hungary, even if their actions provoked a war with Russia.

This 'Blank Check' is one of the most debated actions in modern history. Some historians argue the Kaiser was acting out of impulsive loyalty to his murdered friend, not expecting the crisis to escalate beyond a localized Balkan war. They point to the fact that Wilhelm went on a sailing cruise immediately after giving the promise, suggesting he did not believe a global conflict was imminent.

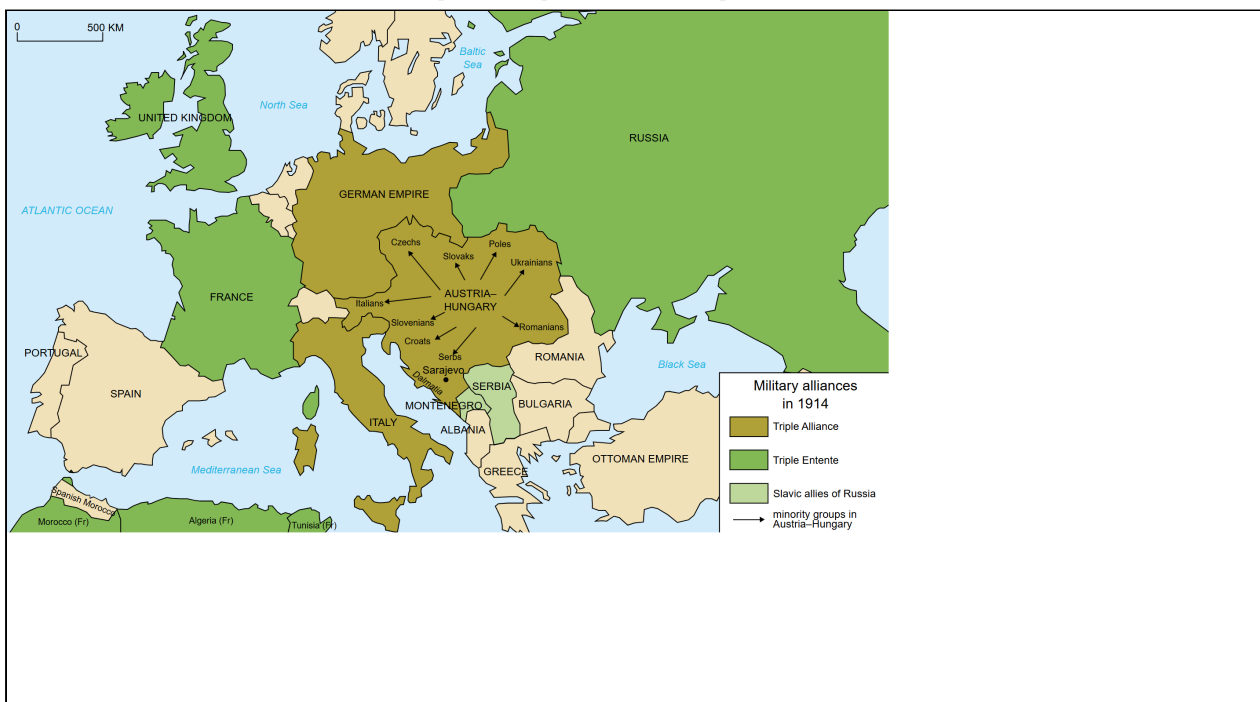
However, other historians argue that the German High Command deliberately used the 'Blank Check' to push Austria into war. Knowing that Russia's military was rapidly modernizing and would soon be too powerful to defeat, German generals believed that if a European war was inevitable, it was better to fight it in 1914 rather than wait. By giving Austria unconditional support, Germany ensured the crisis would explode into a continental conflict.

Interactive Diagram: The Alliance System (1914)



The complex web of treaties that dragged Europe into a global war.

Reference Map: European Military Alliance Blocs (1914)



The Powder Keg: Nationalism vs. Empire

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Qundefined. Was the 'Blank Check' a reckless mistake by the Kaiser, or a calculated move by the German military to trigger a necessary war? Use historical reasoning to justify your stance.

Historian's Corner: The 'Powder Keg' Inevitability

Was war inevitable in the Balkans? Richard Evans argues that the complex alliance system turned the Balkans into a doomsday machine, where any small conflict was mathematically guaranteed to drag all the Great Powers into a general war.

Revision Timeline

Lesson 4: The Alliance System

Map out the key events chronologically. Read the title and prompt to guide your summary.



False Soviet Intelligence

What incorrect information sparked the crisis?

Closure of the Straits of Tiran

Why was this considered an act of war by Israel?



Operation Focus

How did Israel achieve total air superiority?

Capture of East Jerusalem

What was the significance of taking the Old City?

UN Resolution 242

What 'land for peace' formula was proposed?

KT2.2: The Spark in Sarajevo

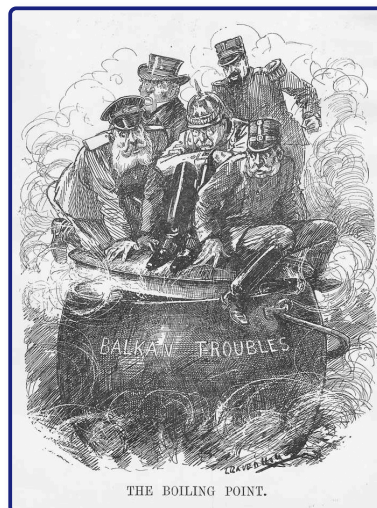
Enquiry: How did the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand trigger the outbreak of the Great War?

By the end of this lesson, I can:

- ☐ Identify the events of 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Explain how the assassination triggered the alliance system.
- ☐ Analyze whether the resulting war was inevitable or accidental.

Qundefined. Look at the men sitting on the 'Balkan Troubles' pot. What are they desperately trying to prevent?

Source A: Leonard Raven-Hill, 'The Boiling Point', a British political cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1912.



What is this source showing? This famous cartoon represents the Balkans region as a boiling pot of ethnic and nationalistic tensions. The leaders of the European Great Powers (Britain, Germany, France, Russia, Austria-Hungary) are shown sitting on the lid, struggling to prevent the pot from exploding into a major European war.

Do Now Activity

1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente?

2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance?

3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace.

4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security?

5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war?

6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading?

7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners?

8. PAST TOPIC: What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

9. PAST TOPIC: Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

10. PAST TOPIC: How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

Vocabulary Focus

Task: Read the key terms and their definitions. Choose **two** terms and write a single, historically accurate sentence that connects them.

undefined: A revolutionary type of heavily-armoured battleship introduced by Britain in 1906.

undefined: A competition between nations to achieve superiority in the quantity and quality of military weapons.

The region of south-east Europe known as the Balkans had once been ruled securely by the Turkish Ottoman Empire. However, as Turkish power weakened across the 19th and early 20th centuries, the Ottoman Empire lost control. Different Balkan states began fiercely demanding their own independence, sparking a series of local Balkan Wars that left the entire area a hotbed of hatred, suspicion, and aggressive militarism.

For the neighboring empire of Austria-Hungary, this was an absolute nightmare. Austria-Hungary was a vast empire containing many different nationalities who wanted independence. Its politicians deeply feared that if Serbian nationalism rose unchecked, the millions of Serbs living inside the Austro-Hungarian borders would rebel, causing the entire empire to collapse. Tensions exploded in 1908 when Austria officially the provinces of Bosnia and Herzegovina, directly absorbing thousands of furious Serbs into its territory. In response, a group of radical Serbian army officers formed a secret terrorist society dedicated to uniting all Serbs by force: the Black Hand.

Qundefined. Explain why the rise of independent Balkan states and Serbian nationalism represented a catastrophic nightmare for the Austro-Hungarian Empire.

By June 1914, the Balkan powder keg was ready to blow. To show the rebellious Serbs who was boss, the heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, Archduke Franz Ferdinand, scheduled a high-profile state visit to Sarajevo, the capital of Bosnia. The date chosen was June 28—the sacred national day of the Serbian people. Thanks to extensive press publicity, the Black Hand knew exactly where the Archduke's open-top car would drive along the river-front . Six young assassins positioned themselves along the quay armed with bombs, pistols, and suicide capsules.

Qundefined. Detail how the structural failure of the first bomb plot inadvertently led to the exact scenario where Gavrilo Princip was able to shoot the Archduke.

The initial assassination attempts failed completely. One terrorist couldn't get his gun out, another went home out of pity, and a third threw a bomb that bounced off the Archduke's car and exploded under the vehicle behind. Furious, Franz Ferdinand canceled the rest of his itinerary and decided to head back to the train station, ordering his driver to stop by the hospital first to visit the wounded officers. However, the route map was altered and the drivers took a critical wrong turn onto Franz Josef Street. Realizing the error, the drivers stopped and attempted to reverse.

Qundefined. Outline the chronological sequence of events from July 23 to August 4, 1914, that transformed a local Balkan assassination into a total European war between alliances.

The car ground to a halt a fraction of a second away from where 19-year-old Black Hand assassin Gavrilo Princip was standing. Seizing his unexpected luck, Princip stepped forward, pulled his pistol, and fired twice into the car. One bullet tore through the Archduke's throat; the second struck his wife, Sophie, in the stomach. Both died within minutes.

Qundefined. Contrast the historical argument of Tony Howarth (Interpretation 3), who blames competing nationalist ideologies, with Germany's military leaders who blame external threats.

This local double-murder triggered a rapid, unstoppable countdown to global war. Backed by Germany's unconditional promise of absolute military support—known as the 'blank cheque'—Austria-Hungary issued a harsh, unacceptable ultimatum to Serbia on July 23. Blaming Serbia for the assassination, they subsequently declared war on July 28, shelling Belgrade. Russia immediately mobilised its massive army to protect its fellow Slavic state, Serbia. Because the German Schlieffen Plan required an immediate land invasion of France through neutral Belgium, Great Britain was bound by the to honor its promise to protect Belgian neutrality. On August 4, 1914, Britain declared war on Germany. The complex system of long-term alliances, imperial greed, and land arms races had successfully dragged the entire world down the path to an unprecedented slaughter.

The 37 days between the assassination in Sarajevo and the outbreak of war are known as the July Crisis. During this frenzied period, diplomats and monarchs across Europe scrambled to react as the rigid alliance system began pulling their nations toward the abyss. What makes the July Crisis so tragic is how many desperate, last-minute attempts were made to hit the brakes.

Qundefined. Explain why the assassination in Sarajevo acted merely as a contributory trigger to set off a general explosion, rather than being the lone necessary cause of the war.

The most famous of these attempts was the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams'—a series of deeply personal, frantic messages exchanged between Kaiser Wilhelm II and Tsar Nicholas II of Russia, who were cousins. Both monarchs pleaded with each other to stop military mobilizations, signing their telegrams with familiar nicknames. However, neither leader was willing to be the first to stand their armies down, fearing they would be left defenseless if the other attacked.

Qundefined. How useful are Source A and Source B together to a historian researching why the European alliance system failed to maintain peace in July 1914?

Ultimately, the crisis revealed a terrifying reality: the civilian politicians and monarchs had lost control of the situation to their military generals. Military timetables, such as Germany's rigid Schlieffen Plan and Russia's immense mobilization schedules, were so

inflexible that once the train of war started moving, it could not be stopped. The alliance system, intended as a deterrent, had instead become a doomsday machine.

Qundefined. What is the main difference between Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 regarding who or what was to blame for starting the First World War?

When war broke out in 1914, it was not just a European conflict. Because of the aggressive Scramble for Colonies (Lesson 2), millions of colonized people across Africa, Asia, and the Middle East were dragged into a war they had no part in causing. Without the immense sacrifices of these colonial troops and laborers, the European empires would have collapsed.

Qundefined. Suggest why Interpretation 1 and Interpretation 2 give different views on the causes of the war.

The July Crisis (1914) - The Domino Effect

Qundefined. Explain how the creation of Poland and Czechoslovakia in 1919 acted as a strategic boundary buffer between Germany and the newly formed Soviet Union.

Interactive Diagram: The July Crisis Domino Effect



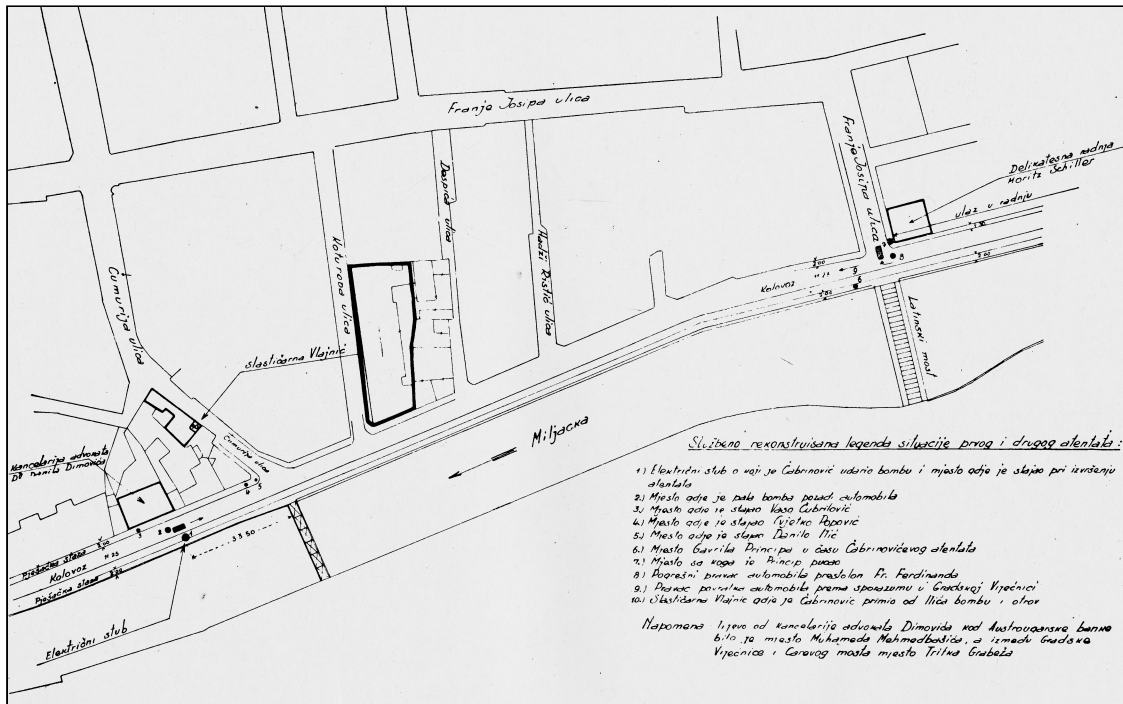
How a single assassination in the Balkans escalated into a world war within a month.

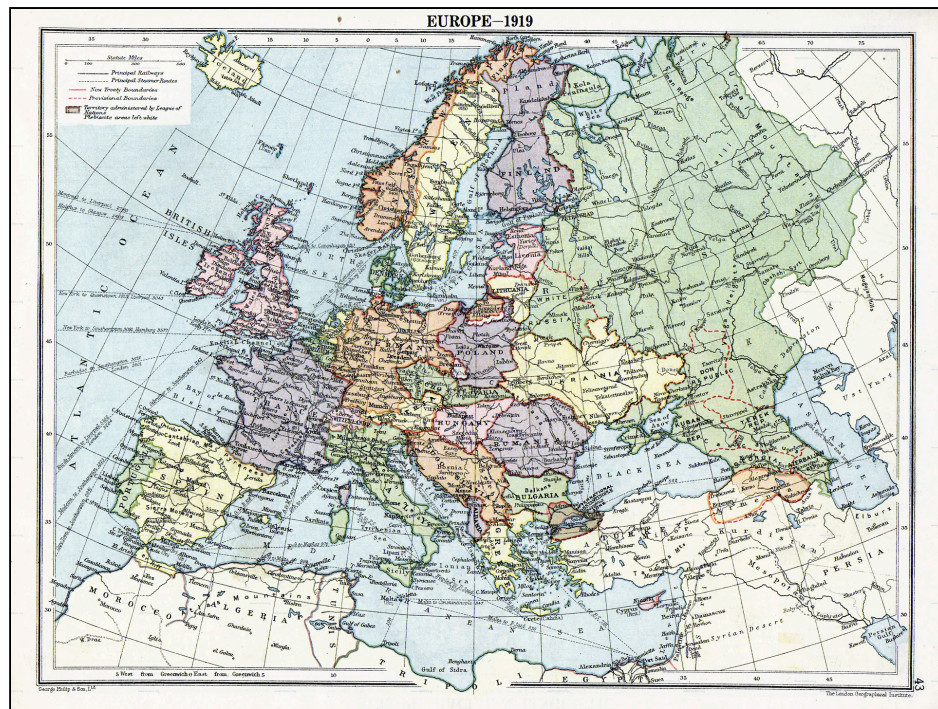
Map A: The Balkan Peninsula (1914)



Simplified map of the highly unstable Balkan Peninsula in 1914.

Map B: Inset - Sarajevo, 28 June 1914: The Fatal Route





The July Crisis: Inevitable or Preventable?

Historian's Corner: The Fischer Controversy

In 1961, German historian Fritz Fischer shocked the world by arguing that Germany deliberately caused WWI to achieve world power status. He pointed to the 'Blank Cheque' as evidence that Germany actively pushed Austria into war, knowing it would provoke Russia.

Revision Timeline

Lesson 5: The Spark in Sarajevo

Map out the key events chronologically. Read the title and prompt to guide your summary.



War of Attrition

How did Egypt attempt to wear down Israeli forces?

Rise of Yasser Arafat

How did Arafat transform the PLO?



Battle of Karameh

Why was this a psychological victory for Fatah?

Dawson's Field Hijackings

How did the PFLP gain international attention?

Black September

Why did King Hussein expel the PLO from Jordan?

End of Unit Quiz Pack

Instructions: Answer the 50 quick-fire recall questions below. If you get stuck, the scrambled answers are provided in the Answer Bank on the final page.

1. In what year did the Franco-Prussian War end?

2. Which wealthy region did Germany take from France in 1871?

3. What was the French desire for revenge called?

4. Who was the German Chancellor that unified Germany?

5. What was Bismarck's greatest strategic fear?

6. Which two countries did Bismarck fear would ally against Germany?

7. What was the secret 1887 agreement between Germany and Russia?

8. Which ambitious German Emperor dismissed Bismarck in 1890?

9. What was Wilhelm II's aggressive global policy called?

10. What previous policy of Bismarck's focused on European peace?

11. What agreement did Britain and France sign in 1904?

12. In which African country did Wilhelm provoke crises in 1905 and 1911?

13. What was the result of the First Moroccan (Tangier) Crisis?

14. What name was given to Germany's aggressive threat of military force?

15. What was the name of the German gunboat sent to Agadir in 1911?

17. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

19. What was Britain's traditional foreign policy of avoiding European alliances called?

21. What volatile region was known as the 'Powder Keg of Europe'?

23. Which empire was retreating from the Balkans, leaving a power vacuum?

25. Which region did Austria-Hungary formally annex in 1908?

27. Who was the heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne?

29. On what date was the Archduke assassinated?

16. What was the British policy requiring their navy to be larger than the next two combined?

18. Why did the Dreadnought ironically threaten British supremacy?

20. What was German Admiral Tirpitz's naval strategy called?

22. What declining multi-ethnic empire dominated the northern Balkans?

24. Which nation wanted to unite all South Slavs into a 'Greater' nation?

26. Which major power considered itself the protector of the Slavic people?

28. In which city was the Archduke assassinated?

30. Who assassinated the Archduke?

31. What secret Serbian society did the assassin belong to?

33. What is the month of diplomatic failures after the assassination called?

35. Which country began mobilizing its army to protect Serbia?

37. Which neutral country did Germany invade to attack France?

39. What was the alliance of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy called?

41. What treaty ended the First World War in 1919?

43. What is the term for a war launched to destroy a rising threat before it gets too strong?

45. Which historian argued the nations blundered into war due to rigid alliances?

32. What unconditional promise did Germany give Austria-Hungary in July 1914?

34. What did Austria-Hungary issue to Serbia on July 23?

36. What was the name of Germany's military strategy for a two-front war?

38. Which country declared war on Germany due to the invasion of Belgium?

40. What was the alliance of Britain, France, and Russia called?

42. Which clause forced Germany to accept full responsibility for the war?

44. Which historian famously argued Germany planned a war of aggression?

46. What was the 'quarantine line' of new states created after WWI called?

47. Name one new state created by the Treaty of Versailles.

49. What ideological threat did the Allies want to separate from Germany after the war?

48. What European power was completely dismantled by the peace treaties?

50. Which country did Germany invade on 3 August 1914?

Quiz Pack Answer Bank

1871 • A war on two fronts (Encirclement) • Alsace-Lorraine • An ultimatum • Archduke Franz Ferdinand • Article 231 (War Guilt Clause) • Belgium • Belgium • Bosnia • Britain • Britain and France grew closer, isolating Germany • Cordon Sanitaire • France and Russia • Fritz Fischer / Max Hastings • Gavrilo Princip • Gunboat Diplomacy • HMS Dreadnought • It made all older ships obsolete, resetting the naval race • June 28, 1914 • Kaiser Wilhelm II • Margaret MacMillan • Morocco • Otto von Bismarck • Poland / Czechoslovakia • Preventative War • Realpolitik • Revanche • Risk Theory • Russia • Russia • Sarajevo • Serbia • SMS Panther • Soviet Communism • Splendid Isolation • The 'Blank Check' • The Austro-Hungarian Empire • The Austro-Hungarian Empire • The Balkans • The Black Hand • The Entente Cordiale • The July Crisis • The Ottoman Empire • The Reinsurance Treaty • The Schlieffen Plan • The Treaty of Versailles • The Triple Alliance • The Triple Entente • The Two-Power Standard • Weltpolitik (World Policy)